

**UNITED STATES OF AMERICA  
BEFORE THE  
FEDERAL ENERGY REGULATORY COMMISSION**

**Interconnection of Large Loads to the  
Interstate Transmission System**

**Docket Number: RM26-4-000**

**INITIAL COMMENTS OF IRON MOUNTAIN DATA CENTERS**

Iron Mountain Data Centers, LLC (“Iron Mountain”) respectfully submits the following initial comments regarding the Secretary of Energy’s (“Secretary”) October 23, 2025 proposed advance notice of proposed rulemaking (“proposed ANOPR”) under section 403 of the Department of Energy Organization Act. On October 27, 2025, the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission (“FERC” or “Commission”) issued its Notice Inviting Comments (“Notice”) and on November 7, 2025 issued its Notice Granting Extension of Time (“Extension Notice”).

Iron Mountain is a provider of colocation data center services. In connection with these business operations, Iron Mountain, through its affiliates, owns and operates data centers and related infrastructure throughout the United States and around the world and is currently developing new data centers that will interconnect to the United States interstate transmission grid. Overall, Iron Mountain advocates for policy initiatives that enhance the flexible deployment of data center infrastructure to support our growing digital economy. Iron Mountain also supports the principle of paying its fair share and not creating a cost shift for other customers.

**I. SUPPORT MOVING PROPOSED ANOPR GOING FORWARD**

Iron Mountain largely supports the Commission expeditiously moving the Secretary’s proposed ANOPR forward to a NOPR and eventually a FERC order. As set forth in the Secretary’s October 23, 2025 filing, invoking limited Commission jurisdiction over the interconnection of large loads to the transmission system is in line with recent FERC orders on the interconnection

of generation resources and regulating transmission under the Federal Power Act. The proposed ANOPR lays out a framework that, if implemented, would provide Iron Mountain and other similarly situated customers enhanced flexibility when interconnecting to the interstate transmission grid. Furthermore, the proposed ANOPR does not interfere with state jurisdiction as required under the Federal Power Act since states and regulated public utilities will still be allowed to charge its retail customers just and reasonable rates, while FERC exercises its role to regulate the bulk transmission system. If done correctly, facilitating large loads to interconnect under federal regulation would provide efficient and cost-effective processes that result in fair cost allocation for all electric customers. This could lead to large load customers being able to access wholesale markets with FERC oversight and provide better overall load forecasting.

In addition, existing interconnection agreements should be exempted from actions the Commission orders as part of this docket and any new orders should be prospective.

## **II. FEDERAL CUSTOMER INTERCONNECTION PRINCIPLES**

Iron Mountain supports the proposed ANOPR because it would provide nationwide process standardization and certainty with the potential for speed to power. It also supports federal and state initiatives to align generation and transmission and build new resources. Given the plethora of comments the Commission is likely to review in response to the Notice and that at this stage, the question before FERC is whether to move forward to a full NOPR, Iron Mountain sets forth the principles that the Commission should take into account.

- 1) *Find preferred solutions to interconnecting large loads timely.*
- 2) *Focus on cost allocation that is fair for all.*
- 3) *In areas with existing available generation and transmission, recover costs through just and reasonable rates instead of deploying capital for collateral and other risk instruments.*
- 4) *Continue to develop rationale solutions that result in savings for all customers*

*through customer owned resources, load flexibility and facilitating speed to power.*

The proposed ANOPR presents an opportunity to study generation and transmission concurrently. When reviewing the Secretary's proposal, the Commission should take lessons learned from MISO and SPP to expedite generator interconnections, allow cluster studies and study transmission projects across Regional Transmission Organizations ("RTOs"). For example, MISO's recently approved Expedited Resource Addition Study ("ERAS") process provides a targeted solution to get needed generation resources interconnected and online to meet the same load challenges as justification for the proposed ANOPR. These processes have allowed generators to connect to the grid faster and provide the necessary energy and capacity to power the digital energy economy. This analysis should be broadened for the interconnection of large loads to include batteries, demand response, pipelines and other tools that can facilitate expedited resource additions. If the proposed ANOPR is broadened, large load customers could have other mechanisms to accommodate their growing energy demands.

This expanded analysis should be coupled with cost allocation models that facilitate deploying capital to projects instead of risk products. In many jurisdictions, utilities are requiring large loads to post collateral and other financial instruments for the length of electric service agreements based on the premise that it mitigates risk. This unnecessarily ties up capital at a time when it should be deployed on new infrastructure and resources. Allowing large load customers to directly pay for these transmission and generation investments would provide a more efficient use of capital while at the same time also derisking utilities and other load serving entities. Shifting capital from collateral to investments would benefit all ratepayers through enhanced and expedited grid investments, correct cost allocation and revenues that can be spread to all customer classes.

Finally, the Commission should consider how the proposed ANOPR will incorporate Grid

Enhancing Technologies (“GETs”)<sup>1</sup> such as long duration storage. By incorporating GETs, the Commission would be facilitating grid planners understanding of additional resources that can maximize and optimize the grid. Iron Mountain is a conditional recipient of a grant as part of the Department of Energy’s (“DOE”) Grid Resilience and Innovation Partnerships program.<sup>2</sup> Through this program, one of Iron Mountain’s options is to deploy a 115MW two-hour battery in the Commonwealth of Virginia. The goal is to demonstrate batteries as a GET and demonstrate the opportunities for data centers to be flexible grid resources. Iron Mountain has encountered potential limitations with state regulated interconnection and tariff processes that effectively remove economic incentives to manage load and during peak grid demands – a benefit for all utilities and customers. The proposed ANOPR could be improved by allowing large load customers to pay directly for improvements on the interstate transmission grid, including GETs, instead of having these costs recovered through retail utility minimum demand charges or other tariff mechanisms that limit the utilization of these investments. Overall, the Commission should continue to provide additional opportunities for the development of GETs and other investments to make grid connections more flexible.

### **III. TREATMENT OF EXTREMELY LARGE LOADS**

As discussed in these comments Iron Mountain supports the proposed ANOPR. However, there are areas where extremely large loads will fundamentally have significant impacts on the bulk power system and should be treated differently. The proposed ANOPR currently would apply to all large loads over 20 MW. In addition, Iron Mountain would propose there be a different

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<sup>1</sup> [https://inl.gov/content/uploads/2024/03/POWER\\_Grid-Enhancing-Technologies.pdf](https://inl.gov/content/uploads/2024/03/POWER_Grid-Enhancing-Technologies.pdf)

<sup>2</sup> <https://www.ironmountain.com/data-centers/about/news-and-events/news/2024/august/data-centers-imdc-gets-grant-of-50m-for-developing-on-site-battery-storage-by-va-doe>

interconnection path for large loads in a single area that are over a percentage threshold of the host utility's peak load or the local balancing authority's capacity. These extremely large loads should be treated separately because normal transmission and generation planning processes could be very challenging to accommodate the impacts on the bulk power system.

#### **CONCLUSION**

As detailed above, Iron Mountain supports the proposed ANOPR and looks forward to working with the Secretary, the Commission and other stakeholders in achieving the principles set forth in these comments.

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*Respectfully submitted,*



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